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Heidegger on Modern Loneliness

Source: Jennifer gaffen, ‘Political Loneliness: Modern Liberal Subjects in Hiding’

Heidegger and the "Peculiar Loneliness" of Modernity

- Drawing on *Being and Time* to explore modern loneliness as a paradox:
  - Despite technological conquest of distance, we are no closer to:
    - Ourselves
    - Others
    - The world around us
- Modern instrumental rationality produces proximity without genuine nearness.
- Heidegger's project makes visible a **distinctive form of alienation** embedded within modern existence.

Radical Shift: From Subject to Being-in-the-World

- Heidegger replaces the isolated modern subject with the relational structure of **being-in-the-world (*Dasein*)**.
- Human existence is not:
  - A self-contained consciousness
  - Defined by fixed essences
- Instead, it is structured by:
  - **Care (*Sorge*)** – a pre-cognitive orientation "toward nearness"
  - Involvement in a meaningful world
- Existence precedes essence:
  - "The essence of *Dasein* lies in its existence."
  - Human beings are constituted by **possibility**, not substance.

The Forgotten Question of Being

- Central claim: Western metaphysics (from Aristotle onward) has forgotten the question of the meaning of Being.
- Being is:
  - Universally presupposed
  - Yet indefinable and obscure
- Modern philosophy trivializes or ignores this question.
- Heidegger's "fundamental ontology" seeks to:
  - Reformulate the question
  - Clarify the being for whom Being is a concern (Dasein)

Temporality as the Horizon of Being

- *Dasein* is fundamentally temporal, not spatial.
- Temporality includes:
  - Past (thrownness)
  - Future (projection)
  - Present (involvement)
- Finitude (being-toward-death) structures:
  - Understanding
  - Questioning
  - Meaning
- Time is not clock-time but lived, existential temporality.

Phenomenology Reformulated

- Following but revising *Edmund Husserl*, *Heidegger* redefines phenomenology.
- Rejects:
  - Husserl's transcendental ego
  - Cartesian subject-object dualism
- Critiques *René Descartes* for:
  - Separating mind and world
  - Making epistemology central instead of ontology
- Phenomenology becomes:
  - Ontological rather than epistemological
  - A method of uncovering (*aletheia*) rather than securing certainty
- Truth is not correspondence but disclosure through care.

Being-With and the Problem of Inauthenticity

- *Dasein* is always already **being-with (*Mitsein*)** others.
- Yet being-with does not guarantee belonging.
- Instead, *Dasein* initially exists as the **"they-self" (*das Man*)**:
  - Anonymous
  - Leveled-down
  - Instrumentalized
  - Absorbed into social norms
- This condition produces a paradox:
  - Surrounded by others
  - Yet hidden and indistinguishable
- This is the core of **modern loneliness**.

The They-Self and Contemporary Relevance

- Critics accuse *Heidegger* of social pessimism.
- However, the "they-self" resonates with:
  - Algorithmic organization of social life
  - Metrics of accessibility and connectivity
  - Hyper-interconnected modern culture
- Loneliness emerges not from isolation, but from:
  - Overexposure
  - Standardization
  - Loss of existential distinctiveness

Anxiety and the Possibility of Authenticity

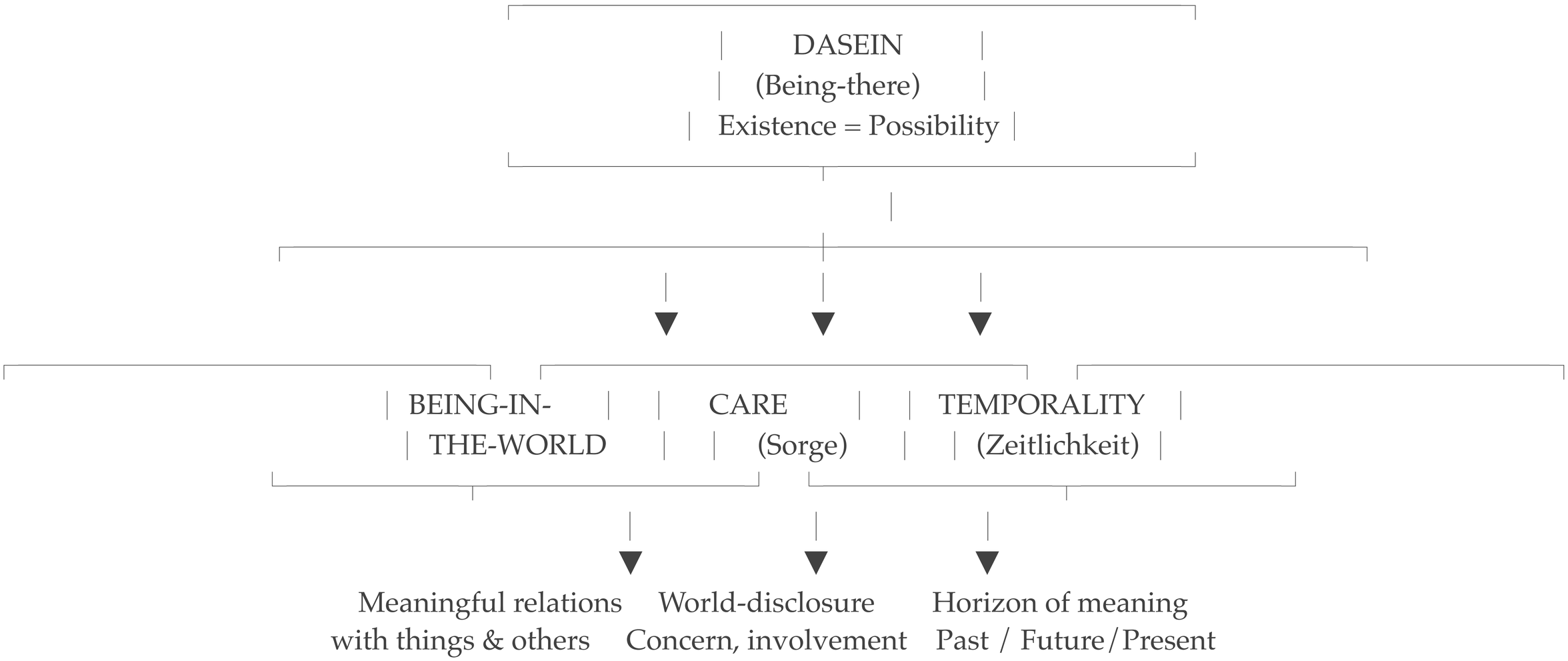
- The “they-self” is inevitable but intolerable.
- In anxiety:
  - *Dasein* is dislodged from anonymous conformity.
  - It confronts its own finite possibilities.
- Authentic existence requires:
  - Owning one’s possibilities
  - Deciding who to be

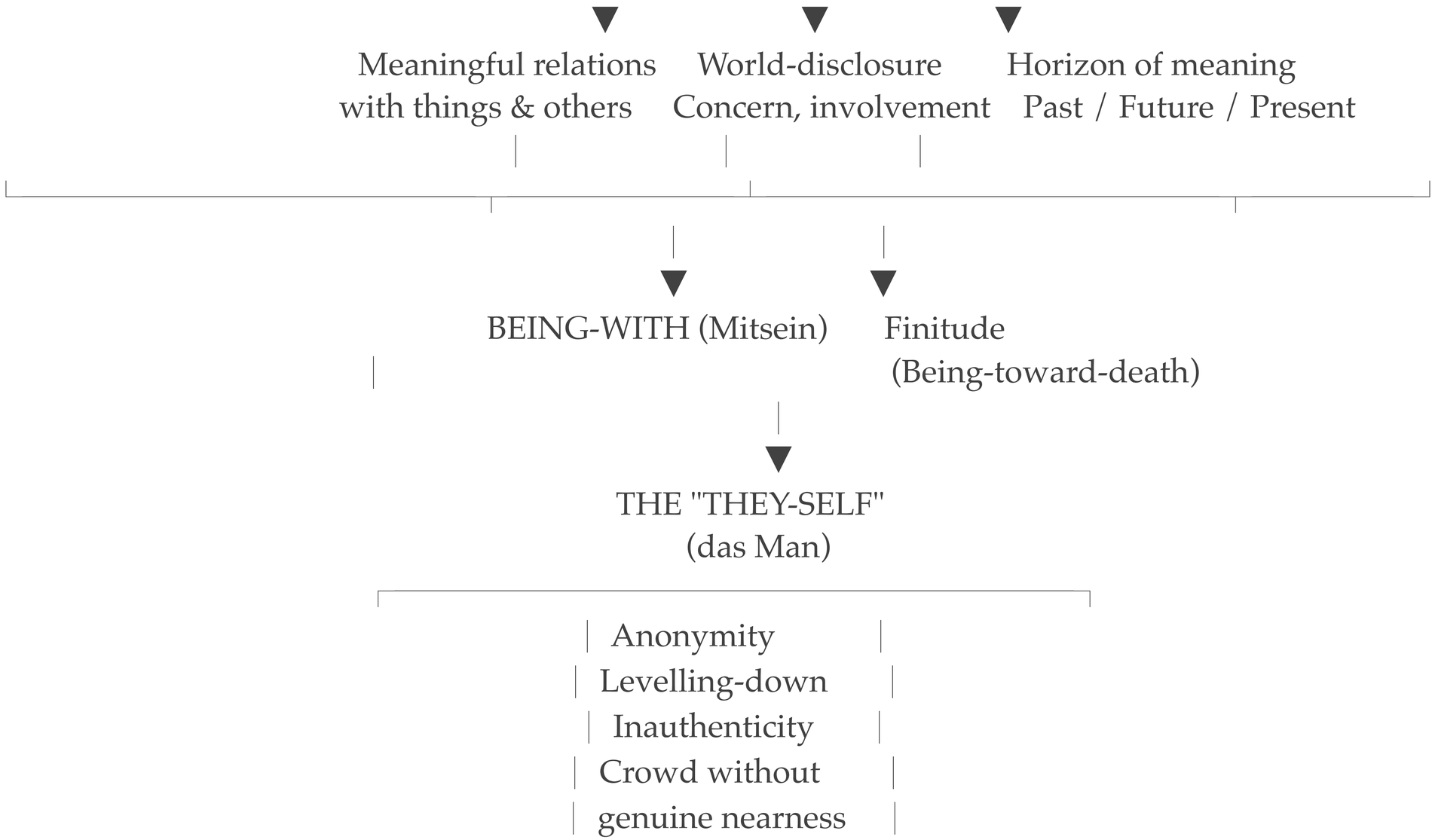
Philosophical Stakes

- Heidegger's intervention:
  - Replaces metaphysics of presence with ontology of existence.
  - Reorients philosophy from epistemology to existential ontology.
- He does not provide a clear political or communal solution.
- However, he leaves a decisive question:
  - How can authentic communal life emerge from inevitable existential loneliness?

Conceptual Tensions

- Relationality vs. alienation
- Connectivity vs. nearness
- Being-with vs. anonymity
- Care as both world-disclosing and world-leveling
- Inevitability vs. intolerability of loneliness
- Ontology vs. epistemology
- Authenticity vs. social absorption


DASEIN
(Being-there)
Existence = Possibility
BEING-IN-
THE-WORLD
CARE
(Sorge)
TEMPORALITY
(Zeitlichkeit)
Meaningful relations
with things & others
World-disclosure
Concern, involvement
Horizon of meaning
Past / Future/Present


Meaningful relations
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BEING-WITH (Mitsein)
Finitude
(Being-toward-death)
THE "THEY-SELF"
(das Man)
Anonymity
Levelling-down
Inauthenticity
Crowd without
genuine nearness

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ANXIETY

POSSIBILITY OF
AUTHENTICITY

Dasein (Existence as Possibility)

- *Dasein* is not a substance but a **being whose essence lies in its existence**.
- It is defined by its **capacity to question Being** and to decide who to be.

Care (Sorge) – The Structural Unity

Care is the **unifying structure** of Dasein and integrates:

- **Thrownness** (past)
- **Projection** (future possibilities)
- **Falling** (absorption in the world)

Care explains:

- Why Dasein is always already involved.
- Why truth is disclosure rather than representation.
- Why alienation is possible.

Temporality – The Horizon

Temporality is the ontological condition of Dasein:

- Past → Thrownness (we inherit a world)
- Future → Projection (we are possibility)
- Present → Engagement (everyday involvement)

Finitude (being-toward-death) individualizes Dasein and makes authenticity possible.

Temporality is not clock-time but the **horizon within which meaning appears**.

Being-With and the They-Self

- Because *Dasein* is being-in-the-world, it is always:
- Being-with others (*Mitsein*)
- However:
- This does not guarantee belonging.
- Dasein initially exists as the **they-self (*das Man*)**.
- The they-self:
- Standardizes meaning.
- Levels differences.
- Produces anonymity.
- Generates a peculiar loneliness:
  - One is surrounded yet hidden.

The Paradox

- The same structures that make world-disclosure possible also make alienation possible:
- Care → makes involvement possible.
- Involvement → risks absorption.
- Being-with → risks anonymity.
- Connectivity → produces loneliness.

Anxiety as Structural Disruption

Anxiety:

- Dislodges *Dasein* from the they-self.
- Reveals its ownmost possibility.
- Makes authenticity possible.

Authenticity is not isolation from others, but a transformed way of being-with.

Structure

Dasein
= Being-in-the-world
= Care
= Temporality
Being-with → They-self → Anonymity → Loneliness
Anxiety → Retrieval of Possibility → Authentic Existence

MODERN SUBJECTIVITY AND THE FORGETFULNESS OF BEING

Dasein as Thrown and Projecting

- *Dasein* (human existence) is always already **"thrown"** into a world it did not choose.
- It is constituted by **temporality**:
  - Thrown from the past
  - Projecting toward future possibilities
- *Dasein* is not first a knowing subject confronting objects; it is **already immersed in a meaningful world**.
- The world is discovered through Dasein's existence as a **"thrown project."**

Being-in-the-World (Not Subject vs. Object)

- Heidegger rejects the idea that being-in is like objects in space (e.g., water in a glass).
- *Dasein* is not a body inside a world of objects.
- Being-in means **dwelling (*wohnen*)** — inhabiting the world with familiarity and concern.
- The traditional "subject–object" model misses the deeper unity of *Dasein* and world.
- *Dasein* is always already "outside" with the world, yet also aware of itself as being-in it.

Care (Sorge) as *Dasein*'s Fundamental Structure

- Not consciousness, but **care (*Sorge*)** is the basic structure of Dasein.
- *Dasein*'s being originates in care and remains defined by it.
- Care is grounded in **temporality**—we are always ahead of ourselves, projecting into the future.
- Human life is structured by anticipation, especially anticipation of death.
- Care gives meaning to the "for-the-sake-of-which" behind all our actions.

Practical Engagement Before Theory

- We encounter things first through use, not detached observation.
- Objects are discovered in their **"handiness" (*Zuhandenheit*)**—their usefulness.
- Example: The hammer is understood best in using it, not staring at it.
- Practical, everyday involvement is more fundamental than scientific knowledge.
- Meaning arises from tasks, projects, and involvement.

Spatiality: De-distancing and Directionality

- *Dasein*'s spatiality is not mathematical distance.
- "De-distancing" means bringing things near in concernful engagement.
- Nearness is existential, not physical measurement.
- Space is disclosed as a meaningful context shaped by *Dasein*'s projects.
- *Dasein* always seeks orientation and familiarity within its world.

Facticity and Destiny

- *Dasein* is bound up with a world larger than itself.
- Facticity means we are always already situated in conditions we did not choose.
- We are never outside being-in-the-world—even if we ignore it.
- *Dasein*'s possibilities are shaped by its entanglement with its world.

Being-With (*Mitsein*)

- Being-in-the-world is always also **being-with-others**.
- The world is always already shared.
- Even tools imply others:
  - A chair is made for someone.
  - The finished product refers back to its maker.
- Meaningful things always carry tacit references to others.

Others vs. Things

- Tools appear in usefulness.
- Other *Daseins* appear as fellow dwellers in care and concern.
- The self is never originally isolated—the "I" emerges within a shared world.
- Even loneliness presupposes being-with.

The Tension of Proximity

- *Dasein* seeks nearness and familiarity with both things and others.
- However, this tendency can lead to absorption in "the they" (*das Man*):
  - Conformity
  - Loss of authentic possibilities
  - A subtle form of loneliness

The Peculiar Loneliness of Being-With

- **Native Relationality Does Not Mean Belonging**
- Although *Dasein* is always already **being-with others**, this does not mean it feels at home.
- Dasein seeks **nearness, familiarity, and guidance** from others.
- In doing so, it often **loses itself**, allowing others to define who it should be.
- Being-with initially takes an **inauthentic** form.

The "They-Self" (*das Man*)

- *Dasein's* everyday self is the **they-self**—shaped by anonymous social norms.
- "The they":
  - Sets standards of judgment and behavior.
  - Levels down uniqueness into **averageness**.
  - Suppresses originality and exception.
- In this mode:
  - "Everyone is the other, and no one is himself."
  - Responsibility is diffused — no one truly owns their choices.
- *Dasein* becomes **"nobody"** rather than a distinct self.

Everyday Deficient Modes of Being-With

- Common modes of concern include:
  - Indifference
  - Passing one another by
  - Treating others as objects
- Even when surrounded by others, *Dasein* experiences a **peculiar loneliness**:
  - Pressed together socially
  - Yet existentially isolated
- The crowd erases distinctiveness.

Publicness and Leveling Down

- "Publicness" controls what counts as valid, acceptable, or meaningful.
- Everything exceptional is flattened into something ordinary.
- The they disburdens *Dasein* of responsibility for its own being.
- This alienation is not accidental — it arises from *Dasein*'s structure as being-with.

Authenticity as a Response

- **Two Modes of Concern for Others**
- Heidegger briefly describes two positive modes:
- **Leaping in**
  - Takes over another's care.
  - Makes the other dependent.
  - Treats them as a task or object.
  - Inauthentic form of help.
- **Leaping ahead**
  - Frees the other for their own possibilities.
  - Enables them to decide who they are.
  - Creates the possibility of "authentic alliance."
  - Respects the other as a "who," not a "what."

Authentic Dasein and Care of the Self

- Authenticity emerges in the mood of **anxiety**.
- *Dasein* confronts its **being-toward-death**:
  - Death is one's "ownmost nonrelational possibility."
  - It radically individuates.
- The **call of conscience** summons *Dasein* back to itself.
- Authenticity requires:
  - Silent, inward resolve.
  - Choosing oneself in light of finitude.
- Care becomes a form of **care of the self**.

Tension in Heidegger's Account

- Authenticity appears to require withdrawal from everyday social immersion.
- This raises a problem:
  - Does authenticity undermine genuine communal life?
- Heidegger later introduces:
  - **Historicity**
  - Fate (*Schicksal*)
  - Destiny (*Geschick*)
  - The shared destiny of a people (*Volk*)

The Problem of Collective Destiny

- Authentic being-with becomes linked to shared historical destiny.
- This shifts focus:
  - From individual singularity
  - To collective fate.
- Raises unresolved tensions:
  - How can radical individuation coexist with collective destiny?
  - Does this risk totalizing or political danger?
- Critics argue Heidegger's solution remains incomplete.

The Loneliness of Togetherness

- Heidegger discovers a paradox:
  - We can be **more connected than ever**
  - Yet **more profoundly lonely**
- The loss of self in the they produces:
  - An intolerable loneliness
  - Especially when we are most socially immersed
- Anxiety disrupts this entanglement and opens the possibility of authenticity.

Questions?

- Is the “they-self” an unavoidable feature of social life?
- Can authentic being-with truly exist, or is authenticity essentially solitary?
- Does Heidegger’s appeal to destiny solve or deepen the problem?
- Is modern hyper-connectivity an intensified version of the they?
- Is loneliness the price of relationality?